India, began to flee by sailing to Madras, Calcutta or Chittagong from the port of Rangoon. However, the port's closure in February 1942 and subsequent closure of different sea routes prompted most evacuees to trek almost 1000 km north towards the Indian border. One route via the Arakan led to Chittagong, another via the Chindwin valley led to Manipur and a third route via the northern passes led to Ledo in north Assam.[6] The journey was undertaken by people across social strata, along congested roads plied by laden ox carts and lorries moving slowly in one direction at difficult altitudes. Estimates suggest that this hurried and unplanned process of evacuation cost anywhere between 10,000 and 50,000 lives due to starvation, exhaustion, diseases, war-related injuries and other reasons. By May 1942, the Japanese military campaign was over and exit routes were sealed even though refugees continued to trickle into India for another two months. A refugee camp survey by the Indians Overseas Department of the Government of India counted close to 4,00,000 people, even though the actual number was likely to be upward of half a million as many evacuees had left the camps for their homes in India. Essentially, India already had a full-blown refugee crisis at hand a good five years before the Partition of 1947.

The refugee crisis occurred a few months before the Quit India Movement was launched by Indian freedom fighters in August 1942. Jawaharlal Nehru latched on to the issue while touring Assam in April 1942, pointing out serious shortcomings in arrangements for the evacuation, including racial discrimination against the Indians.[7] Europeans often had access to safer exit routes and were covered by insurance policies that were not available to the Indians.[8] The lack of adequate resources and frequent mistakes in the evacuation process prompted even British officials to call it 'a horrid mess' and a 'first class disaster'.[9] Problems were complicated further because of harassment, at times, at the hands of the native Burmese nurturing anti-Indian sentiments. Nevertheless, the government built refugee camps with medical facilities along with non-official charitable bodies and organized transport and civil supplies that gradually brought the situation under control. Many evacuees departed for their ancestral homes